

Rappahannock Rivers with minimal resistance. Hooker then turned east, moving his 70,000 men through the wilderness, past a large estate locally known as Chancellorsville, and into the open country five miles to the west of Fredericksburg.

Battle is joined

Lee and his lieutenant, Stonewall Jackson, reacted quickly to the threat. On May 1, Lee left General Jubal Early and 12,000 men to watch Sedgwick at Fredericksburg, while Jackson and the rest of the army marched down the Orange Plank Road to meet Hooker. Near the Zoan Church, General Lafayette McLaws' Division ran head first into part of George Meade's Union Fifth Corps. For a while the Federals pushed McLaws back, but when the Confederate threw in his reserve, they retreated, calling for reinforcements.

Hooker was shocked at the resistance his advance had met. Losing his nerve, he ordered his two forward corps to withdraw to Chancellorsville. The mood among the Union commanders on the night of May 1 was incredulous. Lee and Jackson, on the other hand, could hardly believe their good luck.

Later that night, the Southern chieftains conferred. General J.E.B. Stuart's cavalry scouts had discovered the Union right wing was "hanging in the air" so Jackson and 33,000 troops of his corps would march off through the thick woods on the morning of May 2 to attack the unprotected Federal flank. Lee would keep only 14,000 men to confront all of Hooker's force at Chancellorsville, should he attack.



134,000

62,000

Strength of Hooker's Army of the Potomac at the start of the campaign.

Strength of the Confederate Army of North Virginia on the same date.